

Next Windows Mobile

1,000 developers are already working on the Windows Mobile 7

802.11n finally approved

WiFi 802.11n gets approval - manufacturers hint at 600 Mbps speeds

to the ones found in other premium Gigabyte boards with the bright blue panel covering the heatsinks. The BIOS has overclocking options aplenty.

On the more expensive and extreme-enthusiast boards, the Gigabyte EX58-Extreme, cooling is taken care of by a similar system used in the vanilla EX58-UD3R board. This has the option to add even more heat pipes and heatsinks - but this seems overkill. There are two heat pipes running between the Northbridge and the MOSFET cooling heatsinks on the side. The board has a mix of solid block heatsinks as well as fine fins. The Northbridge is also connected to a huge flat heat sink for the Southbridge. The heat distribution over the board is effective.

One of the problems is with the placement of the standard PCI slots. There is one after the first two PCIe x16 slots. The PCI slots are typically higher than the PCIe slots, so cards with an open cooling with a exposed fan such as the one we were using touch the PCI slot. Unlike the basic X58 board from Gigabyte, there's a neat little power button with the clear CMOS placed right away at the top-end of the board. Most of the overclocking features are identical to the standard board though. There's also a LED poster display on this one.

The ASUS Rampage II Gene is the smaller version of the Rampage II Extreme board for Intel's Nehalem CPUs. There are basic heatsinks connected using anodized pipes. On load, they do heat up quite a lot. This board belongs to the Republic of Gamers family and so it comes with the classy Start and Reset buttons. There is also the LCD poster which gives the user updates on the temperatures, voltages and errors if any. Although this is an mATX board, there is enough space between the two PCIe x16 slots. The audio is powered by a SupremeFX chip



Gigabyte EX58-UD3R

onboard the motherboard and not one that fits into a PCIe slot like some of the other motherboards from ASUS. The Clear CMOS button is conveniently placed at the back of the board and can be accessed from the rear of the cabinet. There are a host of other features like support CPU coolers less gap between the retention pins than regular



MSI X58 PRO

LGA1366 and the absence of retention brackets on one side of the DIMM slots. The ASUS Rampage II Extreme is a gigantic looking board. Everything has the look of extreme quality to it. There are terminals for those who want to use a multimeter to check voltages on the board. Power buttons like the ones on the Rampage II Gene are also positioned there. The heat sink has a light on top of it which gives the board a very nice look. The power sockets for the optional fans are put together at one point so you don't have cables lying all over the place.

Intel's stock X58 board, the

DX58S0 comes with nothing special to interest buyers. This is one of the motherboard packages to come with a free game; in this case, *Ghost Recon Advanced Warrior*. The

Northbridge heat sink is cooled by a flimsy light-weight heat sink. The quick guide manual says that attaching the bundled fan is optional. We think it's a must as this heat sink gets hot quickly and we've seen blue screens in the past while trying to run the board without the fan attached though things cool down a lot with the fan. The Southbridge is stable and under control at all times. The board only has solid state capacitors around the CPU region. There are small heatsinks for the MOSTETs. Like many of Intel's boards, this one too lacks a PS2 port even for the keyboard. The board is ideal for SLI and Crossfire because of the ample space between the two PCIe slots. The BIOS is basic in comparison to all the other boards in its category. The SATA ports on the board point upwards which could come in the way of some cards. Intel has tried to space them out though.

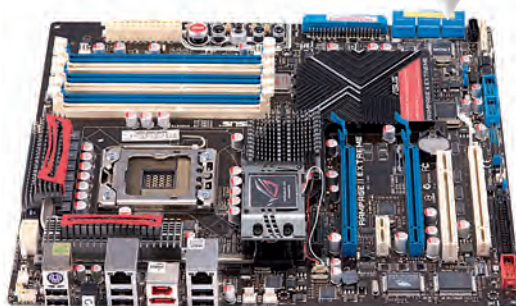
The ASUS P6T Deluxe is another quality board. The quality of the processor bracket and the back plate behind the board are of the highest quality. The board is heavy with a thick copper pipe running between a sequence of heatsinks from the MOSFETs to the Northbridge and ending at the Southbridge. Cooling is very good. There are 8 SATA ports out of which two are SAS ports. SAS ports are

SCSI over Serial ATA and are meant for extreme performance drives. There's plenty of space between the first two PCIe x16 slots and there are two PCI slots in between. The Express Gate module is also conveniently placed in between the PCI slots. The board comes with a nifty little overclocking device called the OC palm. It connects to the system allowing users to overclock and monitor all kinds of activity on the board and off it.

The DFI LANPARTY UT X58-T3eH8 has a very nice bundle. While all the other enthusiast boards try to be serious, this one tries to put on a party hat image with its bright coloured slots and fluorescent rounded cables. A large portion of the motherboard is covered with heatsinks and heat fins surrounding the heat pipes. There's an additional heat sink supplied with the board if you want to attach it to the board or to the Northbridge heat sink. A separate Realtek 885 audio controller module is supplied that has to be connected to the motherboard using a supplied cable without using any PCIe slots. There is no dedicated button to clear the CMOS. Instead, a combination of presses with the power and reset button is to be used besides the usual jumpers. Overclocking feature are plentiful and to extreme detail. The layout of the board might seem a little crowded towards the upper region near the expansion ports, but other than that it's well spaced out.

Performance

The ASUS Rampage II Gene gave us a well balanced score list with all and scored the number one slot under plain performance score list. The larger and full ATX version of the Rampage II Gene, the Rampage II Extreme performed similarly in all the tests except in the file transfer tests. The exciting DFI Lanparty X58 board takes the second place. We noticed that the CPU performance test in Crysis fluctuated a bit across boards while the graphics benchmark



ASUS Rampage II Extreme

